

MEETING 7 and 9

WRITING AN ESSAY

Egyptian hieroglyphs

An **essay** is a piece of writing several paragraphs long. It is about one topic, just as a paragraph is. However, because the topic of an essay is too complex to discuss in one paragraph, you need to divide it into several paragraphs, one for each major point. Then you need to tie the paragraphs together by adding an introduction and a conclusion.

Writing an essay is no more difficult than writing a paragraph except that an essay is longer. The principles of organization are the same for both, so if you can write a good paragraph, you can write a good essay.

The Three Parts of an Essay

An essay has three main parts: an **introduction** (introductory paragraph), a **body** (at least one, but usually two or more paragraphs), and a **conclusion** (concluding paragraph).

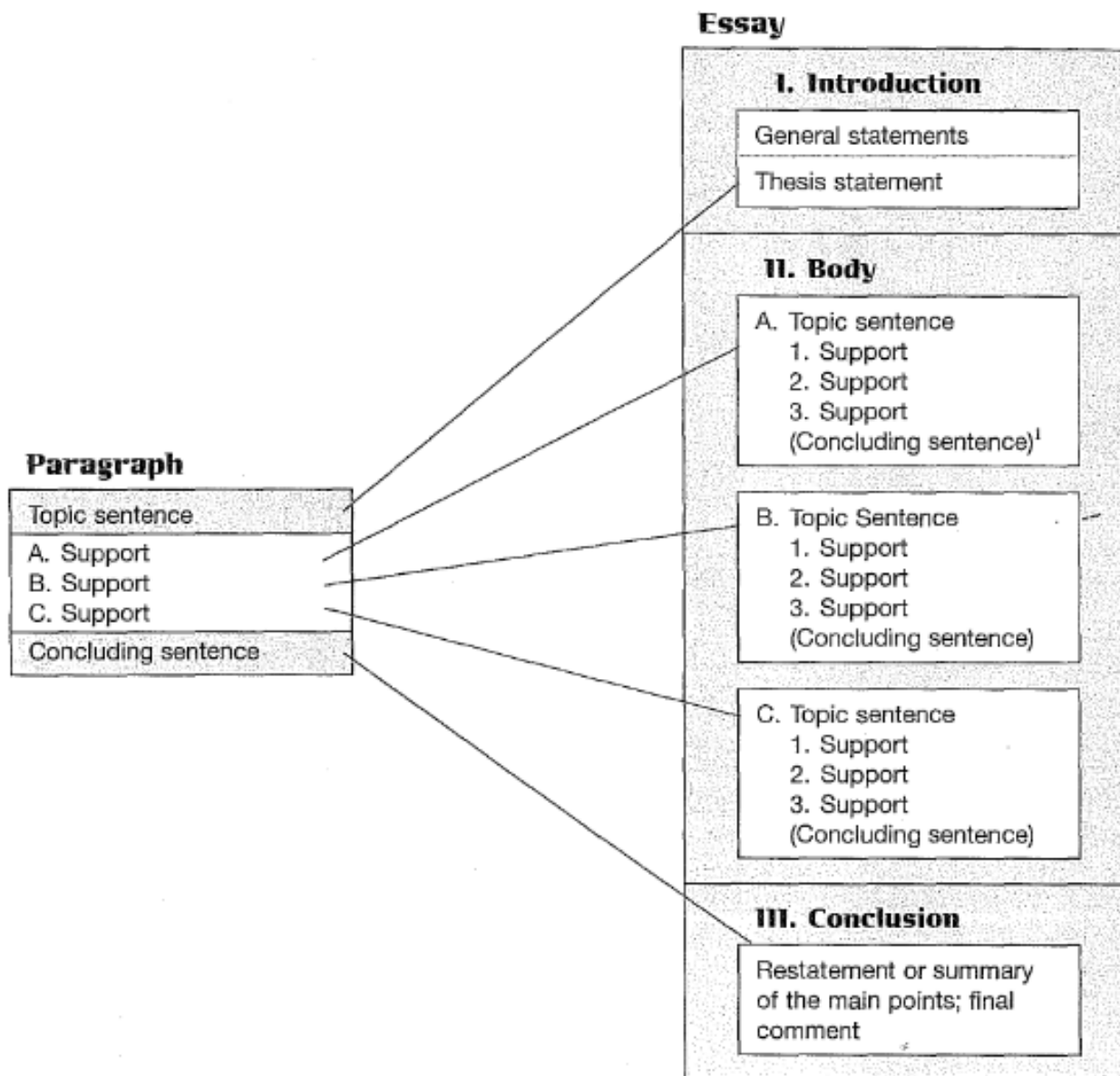
The following chart shows you how the parts of a paragraph correspond to the parts of an essay.

56

An essay **introduction** consists of two parts: a few general statements to attract your reader's attention and a **thesis statement** to state the main idea of the essay. A thesis statement for an essay is like a topic sentence for a paragraph: It names the specific topic and gives the reader a general idea of the contents of the essay. The **body** consists of one or more paragraphs. Each paragraph develops a subdivision of the topic, so the number of paragraphs in the body will vary with the number of subdivisions or subtopics. The **conclusion**, like the concluding sentence in a paragraph, is a summary or review of the main points discussed in the body.

An essay has **unity** and **coherence**, just as a paragraph does. **Transition signals** and the **repetition of key nouns** link the paragraphs into a cohesive whole.

¹Concluding sentences for body paragraphs in an essay are not always necessary, especially when the ideas in consecutive paragraphs are closely related.



Transition signals are words or phrases used to connect ideas, sentences, or paragraphs in writing. They help readers understand the relationship between ideas and make the writing flow more smoothly.

Transition signals can show:

- addition of ideas,
- contrast,
- cause and effect,
- examples,
- sequence,
- or conclusions.

Examples of Transition Signals

- **Addition:** furthermore, moreover, besides
- **Contrast:** however, although, on the other hand

- **Cause and Effect:** therefore, as a result, because
- **Example:** for example, for instance
- **Sequence:** first, next, finally
- **Conclusion:** in conclusion, overall, to sum up

Example in a Sentence

“Social media is useful for communication. **However**, it can also distract students from studying.”

In this sentence, **however** is a transition signal showing contrast between two ideas.

EXERCISES

A. Fill in the Blank

Choose the best transition signal to complete each sentence.

Options: however, therefore, for example, first, in conclusion, moreover, although, as a result

1. _____, students should create a study schedule before exams.
2. Social media is useful for communication; _____, it can reduce students' focus in class.
3. Many students use AI tools for learning. _____, they use ChatGPT to practice English writing.
4. The internet connection was unstable; _____, the online class was delayed.
5. _____ technology offers many benefits, students should use it wisely.
6. Reading books improves vocabulary. _____, it helps students develop critical thinking skills.
7. _____, maintaining a healthy lifestyle is important for both physical and mental health.

B. Insert Appropriate Transition Signals

Add suitable transition signals to make the paragraph more coherent.

Paragraph 1

Online learning has become popular in recent years. _____, students can study from anywhere using digital devices. _____, online learning also has some disadvantages. Some students find it difficult to stay focused during virtual classes. _____, teachers should create interactive activities to keep students engaged.

Paragraph 2

Many university students use social media every day. _____, social media helps them communicate with friends and access information quickly. _____, excessive use of social media may reduce study time. _____, students need to manage their time wisely.

C. Answer the questions below by reading the text.

1. What do you call the first paragraph in this short essay?
2. Which sentence is called thesis statement?
3. What is the controlling idea in the thesis statement?
4. Mention the parts of each body paragraph.
5. Find transition signals in this essay.
6. Find final comment in concluding paragraph.

The Advantages and Disadvantages of Social Media for Students

In the modern digital age, social media plays a significant role in the lives of students. Platforms such as Instagram, TikTok, Facebook, and WhatsApp are used daily for communication, entertainment, and learning. Social media has changed the way students interact with information and with one another. However, while social media offers many advantages in education and personal development, it also brings several disadvantages that can affect students negatively. This essay will discuss both the benefits and drawbacks of social media for students.

To begin with, one of the major advantages of social media is that it provides easy access to information and learning resources. Students can watch educational videos, join study groups, and follow online tutorials that help them understand their subjects better. In addition, social media allows students to collaborate and communicate with peers and teachers outside the classroom. For example, they can share notes, ask questions, or discuss assignments in group chats. Furthermore, social media helps students develop digital literacy skills, which are essential for their future careers in a technology-driven world. In short, one of the main benefits of social media is its ability to provide quick and easy access to information and educational resources.

Another advantage of social media is its ability to connect students globally. Through online platforms, students can make friends from different countries and learn about other cultures. This promotes cultural awareness and open-mindedness, which are important qualities in today's interconnected world. Social media can also serve as a place for students to express creativity, share opinions, and participate in social causes, which helps them build confidence and social responsibility. In other words, the benefit of social media is that it enables students to connect with others around the world.

On the other hand, social media also has several disadvantages that can negatively influence students' academic and personal lives. Firstly, excessive use of social media often leads to distraction and procrastination, causing students to spend less time studying. Secondly, it may contribute to mental health problems, such as anxiety or low self-esteem, especially when students compare themselves to others online. Moreover, social media exposes students to cyberbullying and privacy risks, which can affect their emotional well-being and sense of security. In conclusion, social media also has several disadvantages that can negatively influence students' academic and personal lives.

To sum up, social media has both positive and negative effects on students. It can be a valuable tool for learning, communication, and global connection if used properly. However, it can also cause serious problems when used irresponsibly or excessively. Therefore, students should learn to use social media wisely and in moderation, balancing their academic responsibilities with their online activities. By doing so, they can enjoy the benefits of social media while minimizing its harmful effects.

D. Essay Writing Practice

1. Make some topic sentences about "The Use of AI in Education".
2. Choose one topic sentence develop into one good paragraph.
3. Based on your paragraphs you develop, write a short essay which has two body paragraphs.

Requirements:

Use at least:

2 transition signals for addition

2 transition signals for contrast

1 transition signal for example

1 transition signal for conclusion

Example transition signals:

Addition: furthermore, moreover

Contrast: however, although

Example: for example(s)

Conclusion: in conclusion